

Whispering with your agent

Collaborating with an agent, behind its back

Text-based Task-oriented Agentic

Lucas Loh / A0282987E / lucasloh@u.nus.edu
CS3249 / AY2627 S1 / Critique 1

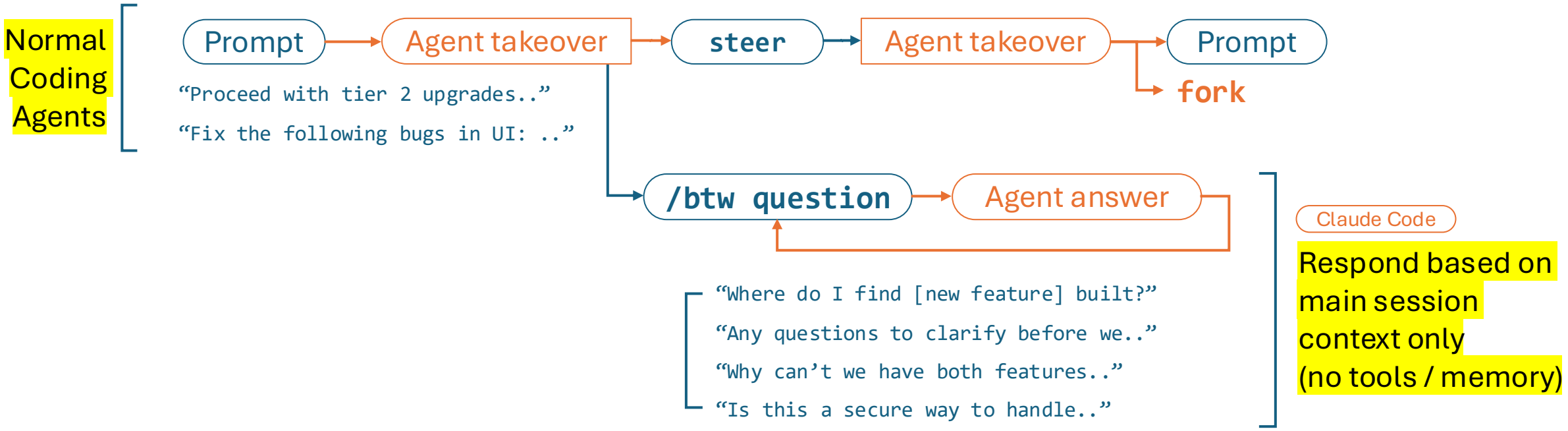
Official Docs

“Use /btw to ask a question about your current work without adding to the conversation history.”

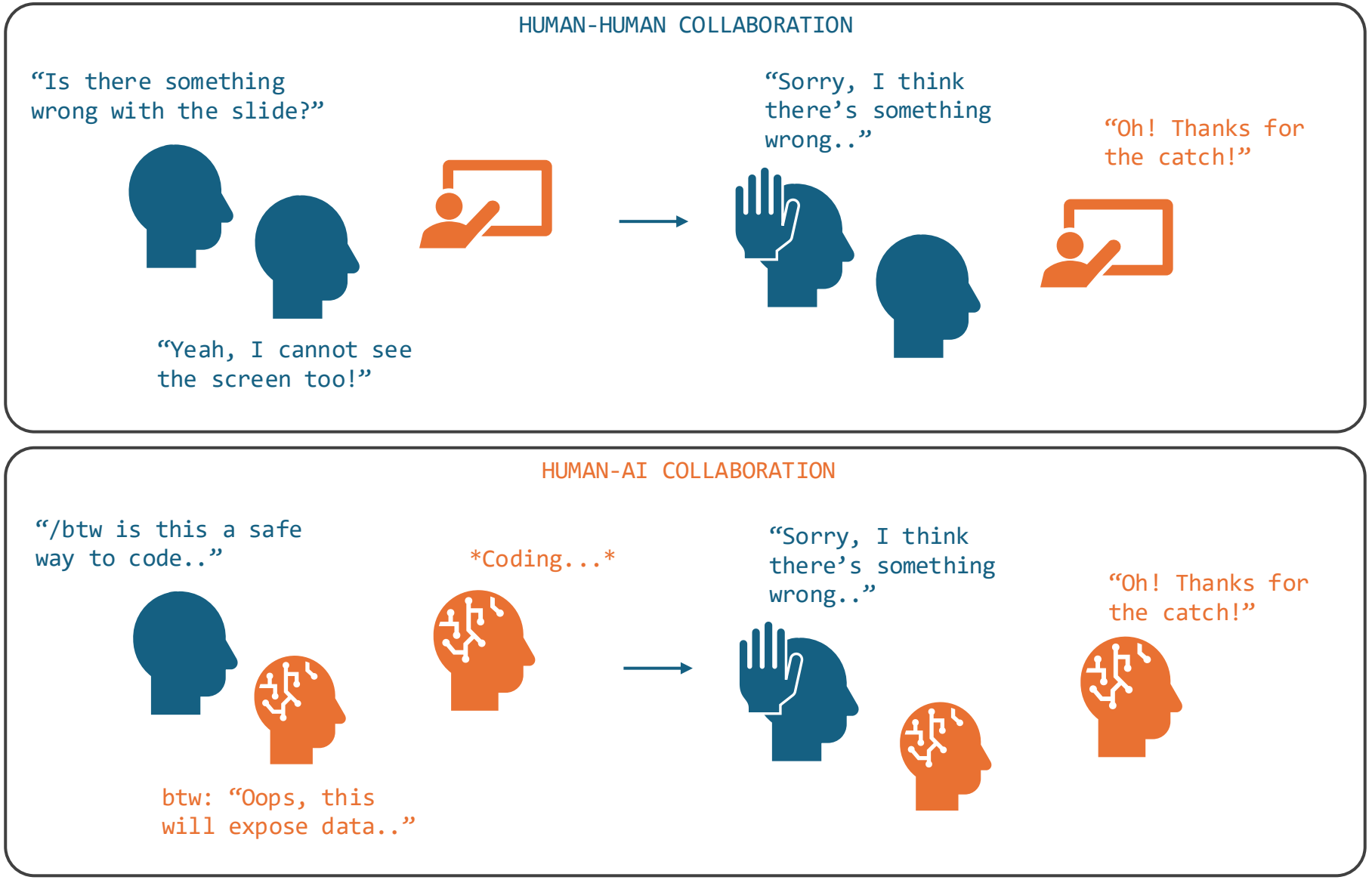
Claude Code documentation, ‘Side questions with /btw’ https://code.claude.com/docs/en/interactive-mode#side-questions-with-%2Fbtw (accessed 31 Aug 2026)

Goal

1. Help users understand what the agent is doing
2. without interrupting it, or affecting main session context



/btw as a whisper

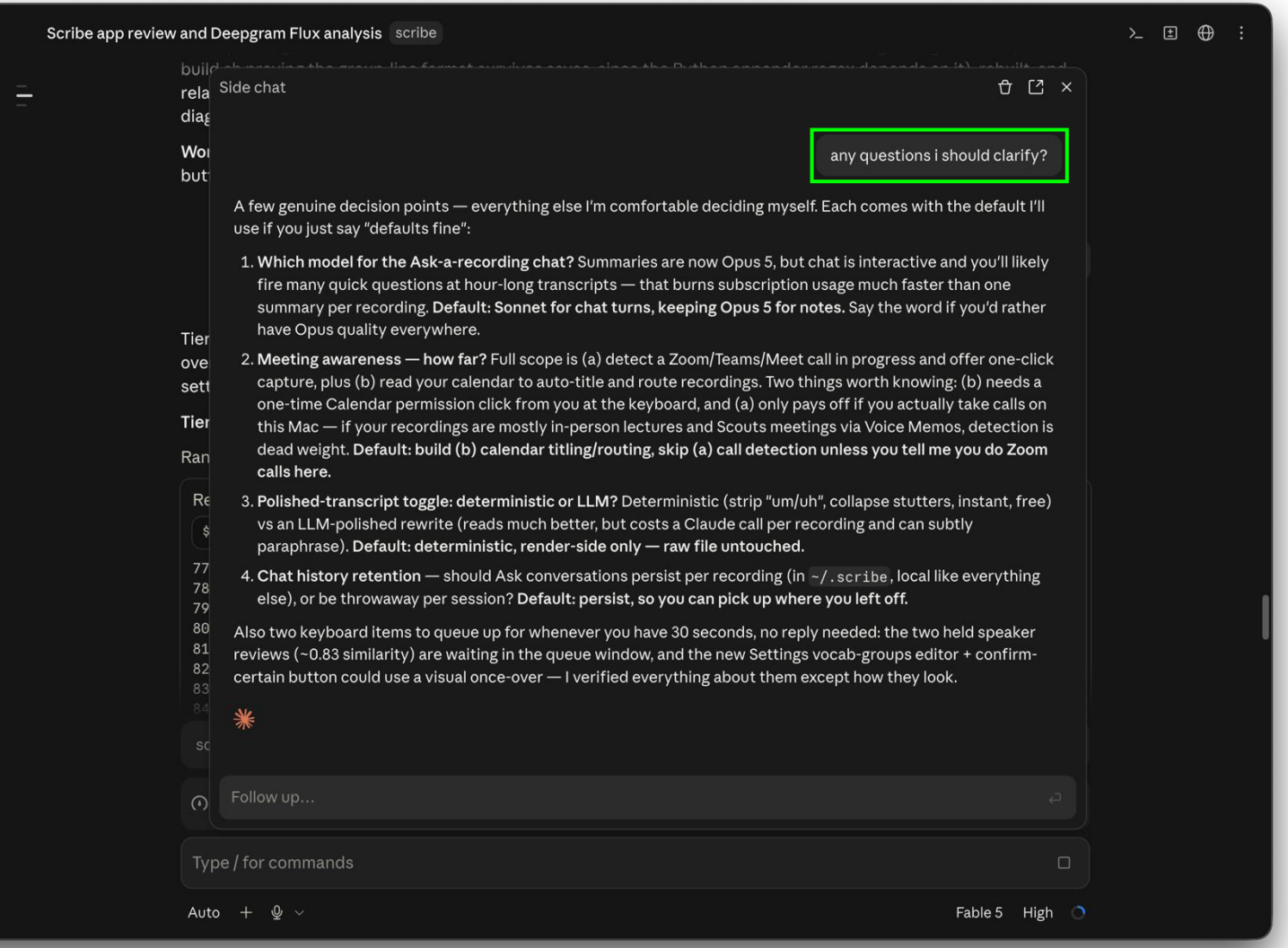


/btw vs. texting in a meeting

(or, students chatting with lecturer is talking)

Asking in main conversation may be disruptive

Agent did not need interjection, user was able to receive clarification



<u>Silent Whispering (Dennis et al., 2010): Instant Messaging at a meeting</u>

Silent Whispering (p. 849-850):

1. Interactivity – able to engage at **any moment**
2. Polychronic – hold conversation in **parallel**
3. Ephemeral – remarks are **tentative**

Benefits of Silent Whispers (p. 864-868):

1. Participation – members unable to get air time can engage at the sidelines
2. Satisfaction – able to seek clarification and contribute their remarks
3. Efficiency – Steps and decisions made in parallel within meeting
4. Politeness – avoid “rude” interruption

Dennis, A. R., Rennecker, J. A., & Hansen, S. (2010). Invisible whispering: Restructuring collaborative decision making with instant messaging. Decision Sciences, 41(4), 845–886. https://doi.org/10.1111/j.1540-5915.2010.00290.x

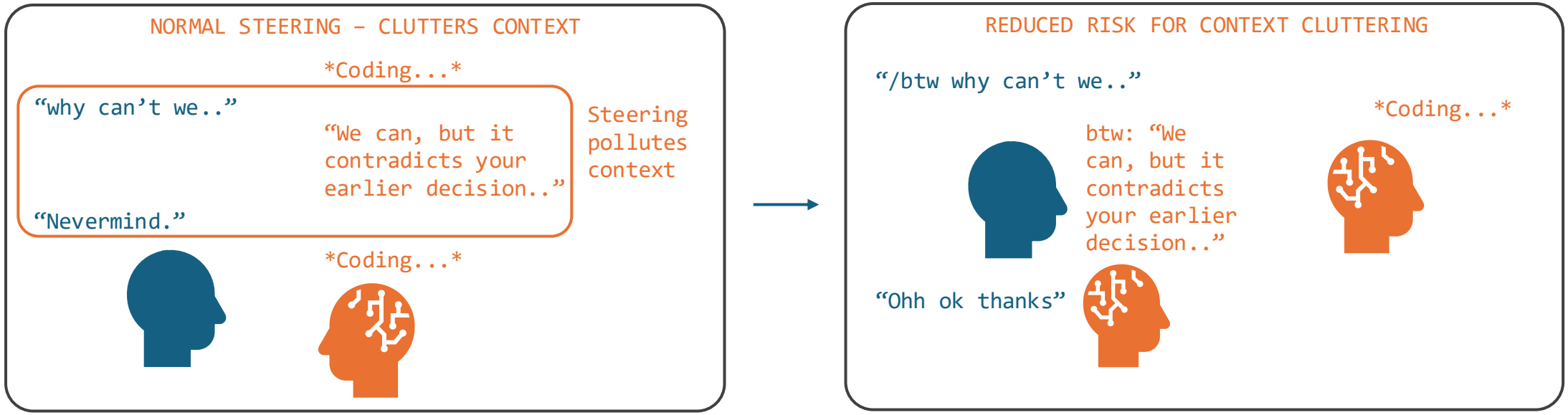
Limit Tests of /btw show it adheres to Claude Code's specs

Claude Code

Main Task	/btw	/btw response	Finding	Insight
General coding task	Asked about a file never opened in main task	Correctly declined to answer, cited not opened	Context is strict subset of main session	/btw is strictly tool-less version of the agent.
Run tests, modify code, run tests again	Asked whether tests passed mid-task	Correctly answered, and also pointed out changes in progress, tests pending	Tool-call level understanding of agent's work, able to answer accurately and precisely	Live view into agent's tool calls and reasoning, allows user to ask and get correct answer any time
General coding task	Asked to add a todo to memory	Claimed to do so (inaccurate) Bug	Did not actually do so, memory protected	/btw has no memory, cannot affect main agent

Automated tests with precise timestamp capture for reproducibility. Tested Model: Claude Sonnet 5.

/btw removes context penalty, encourages user participation

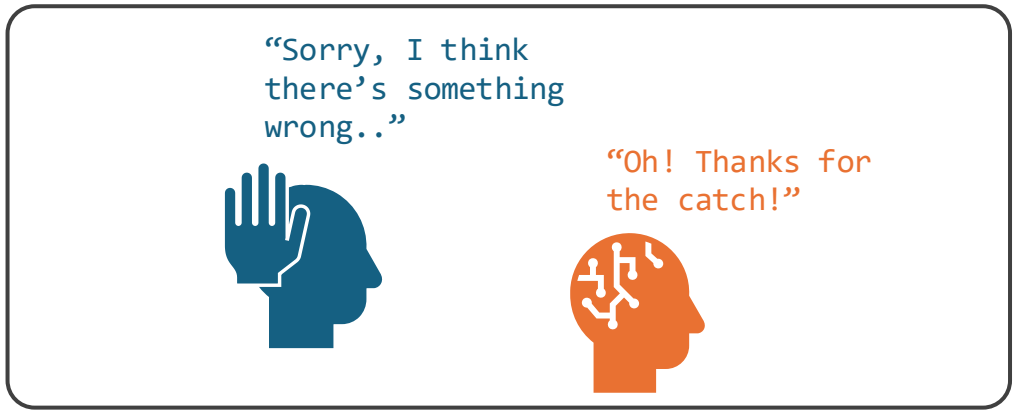


Gap: Discussion and decisions in btw cannot be forwarded to agent

Agent falsely claims it has done things it cannot

/btw	/btw response
Asked to add a todo to memory	Claimed to do so (inaccurate) Bug

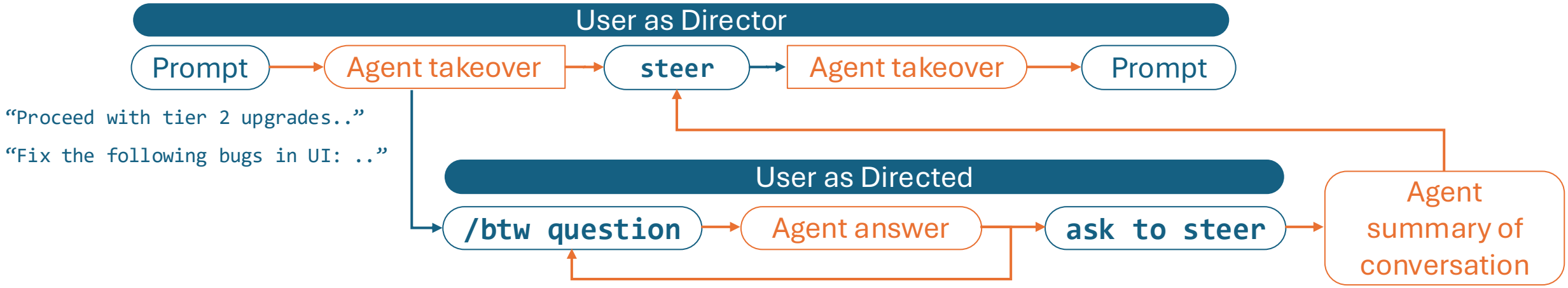
User needs to parse the conversation into a steering prompt



From silent whispering to speaking up at meeting

Claude Code

Feature **Allow /btw to communicate back to main agent through steering**



Agent offers to relay decision points / user directive back to main agent

1. Allows user to explore and ask questions with minimal cost to main context,
2. Reduce cost to steer when user has already communicated to CUI on /btw
3. /btw serves as **hygiene layer** in behavior and communication
4. Relies on agents being directive and clear when communicating with each other